White Oleander

By Janet Fitch

Dear Claire,

Yes, I think it would be marvelous if you'd visit. It's been so long since I've seen Astrid, I don't know if I'd recognize her – and I'm always delighted to meet my loyal readers. I will put you on my visitors list – you've never been convicted of a felony, have you? Just teasing.

Your Friend,

Ingrid

INTRODUCTION

And so they went, against Astrid's better judgment, to visit the woman who genetically had the right to claim Astrid as daughter. After all, Astrid couldn't protect her foster mother, Claire, forever, could she? White Oleander by Janet Fitch

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It was February, a gray morning so overcast we couldn't see the Hollywood Hills from our yard. We were going to visit my mother. Claire had set it up. The idea of this meeting was almost too much to bear. I could only lose. My mother could hurt her. Or she could win her over. I didn't know which was worse. Claire was mine, someone who loved me. Why did my mother have to get in the middle? But, that was my mother, she always had to be the center of attention, everything had to be about her.

I looked in the mirror, imagining what my mother would think of me now. The scars on my face were just the start. I'd been through a few things since then. I wouldn't know how to be with her now, I was too big to hide in her silence. And now I had Claire to worry about.

I had second thoughts about my clothes too, a long skirt and Doc Martens, thick socks, a crocheted sweater with a lace collar from Fred Segal, where all trendy young Hollywood shopped. My mother was going

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to hate it. But I had nothing to change into, all my clothes were like that now.

We drove east for an hour. It had been more than two years since I'd last come this way, a very different girl in pink shoes. We drove back along the same blacktop road to the CIW, the steam stack and the water tower, the guard tower that marked the edge of the prison. We parked in the visitors lot.

Claire took a deep breath. "This doesn't look so bad." We sat at a picnic table under the blue overhang. I watched the gate where my mother would come in. Claire shivered. She was trying to be brave. "Why are they staring at us like that?

It was cold, but now I was sweating, waiting for my mother. Who knew, maybe they would become friends. Maybe my mother wasn't playing a game, or not to ugly a one. I saw my mother, waiting while the CO opened the gate. Her hair was long again, forming a pale scarf across the front of her blue dress, she was as nervous as I was. So beautiful. She always surprised me with her beauty. Even when she had just been away for

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a night, I'd see her and catch my breath. She was thinner than the last time I'd seen her, all the excess flesh had been burned away. Her eyes had become even brighter, I could feel them from the gate. She was very upright, muscular, and tan. She strode up, smiling, but I felt uncertainty in her hands. We looked into each other's eyes, and I was astonished to find that we were the same height. Her eyes were searching within me, trying to find something to recognize. They made me suddenly shy, embarrassed of my fancy clothes, even of Claire. I was ashamed of the idea that I could escape her, even of wanting to. "Welcome to Valhalla," she said, shaking Claire's hand. I tried to imagine how my mother must be feeling right then, meeting the woman I'd been living with, a woman I liked so much I hadn't written anything about her. Now my mother could see how beautiful she was, how sensitive, the child's mouth, the heart-shaped face, the delicacy of her neck, her freshly cut hair. Claire smiled with relief that my mother had made the first move. She didn't understand the nature of poisons.

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She looked older than the last time I saw her, lines etching into her tanned face, around the eyes and thin mouth. I winced at her old-fashioned, actressy diction. I could imagine my mother mocking her later to her cellblock sisters. But I couldn't protect Claire now. It was too late. I saw that the perennial hint of irony in the corners of my mother's lips had now been etched into a permanent line, the tattoo of a gesture.

"My daughter says you're an actress." She wore no sweater in the cold grayness of the morning. The fog suited her, I smelled the sea on her although we were hundred miles from any ocean.

Claire twisted her wedding ring, it was loose on her thin fingers. "To tell you the truth, my career's a disaster. I blotched my last job so badly, I'll probably never work again." Why did she always had to tell the truth? I should have told her, certain people should always be lied to. My mother instinctively felt for the crack in Claire's personal history, like a rock climber in fog sensing fingerholds in a cliff face. "Nervous?" she said kindly. Claire leaned closer to my mother, eager to

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share confidences. "It was a nightmare," she said, and began to describe the awful day.

Overhead the clouds roiled and clotted, like dysentery, and I felt sick. Claire was afraid of so many things, she only went thigh-deep into the ocean because she was afraid of being swept under. So why couldn't she feel the undertow? My mother's smile, so kind-looking. They treat actors so badly," my mother said. "I've had it." "No more. Dragging myself to auditions, just to have them look at me for two seconds and decide I'm too ethnic for orange juice, too classic for TV moms." "That's why Astrid and I get along. Scorpio and Pisces understand one another." My mother didn't like that we understood each other, Claire and I, could tell by the way she was pulling my hair. "Astrid and I never understood each other. Aquarius and Scorpio. She's so secretive, haven't you found that? I never knew what she was thinking." "We just adore her," Claire said, and for a moment I saw her my mother saw her. Actressy, naïve, ridiculous. No, I wanted to say stop, don't judge her based on this. "She's doing wonderfully well, she's

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on the honor roll this year. We're trying to keep that old grade point average up." I was mortified and I didn't want to be. When would my mother have worked with me, hour after hour, to raise the old grade point average?

"Does he have to travel a good deal, your husband? What's his name again? Ron?" "He's always gone," Claire admitted. "He wasn't even home for Christmas." "It must be lonely for you," my mother said. Sadly. So sympathetic. I wished I could get up and run away, but I would never leave Claire here alone with her. "It used to be," Claire said. "But now I have Astrid." I was such a traitor. I had betrayed my master. She knew why I'd kept Claire in the background. Because I loved her, and she loved me. Because I had the family I should have had all this time, the family my mother never thought was important, could never give me. "Astrid, do you mind letting us talk for a moment alone? Some grown-up things." I looked from her to my foster mother. Claire smiled. "Go ahead. Just for a minute." Like I was a kid who had to be encouraged to get into

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the sandbox. She didn't know how long a minute could be, what might happen in a minute.

I got up reluctantly and went over to the fence closest to the road, ran my fingertips over the bark of a tree. I watched them, leaning toward each other over the table. My mother was talking without stopping, low, reasonable, I'd seen her hypnotize a cat this way. Claire was upset. I didn't care what my mother's game was. Her time was up. We were leaving, she was staying. She couldn't screw this up for me, no matter what she said. They both looked up as I rejoined them. My mother glared at me, then veiled it with a smile. "You just remember what I told you." "I'll meet you in the car," she said.

My mother and I watched her go. "What did you tell her?" " I hear she's having trouble with her husband." She smiled sensually, "It's not you, is it? I know you have an attraction to older men." "No, it's not me." She couldn't play with me the way she played with Claire. "You stay out of it." I could see it startled her to have me oppose her. It angered her that I felt I

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could, but she was controlled, I could see her switch gears. "I have to do what I can for my new friend." "Just leave her alone." "Oh, but it's fun," my mother said. "Don't screw it up for me." "What could I do? I'm a poor prisoner. A little bird with a broken wing." "If you love me, you'll help me." "Help you, darling? I'd rather see you in the worst kind of foster hell than with a woman like that." She grabbed my wrist, forcing me to look at her. Now she was dead serious. "What are you going to learn from a woman like that?" "How to pine artistically? She stood and kissed me on the cheek, embraced me lightly. "All I can say is, keep you bags packed." "I think I did well with you mom, don't you?" "You did," I told her, gazing out the window so I wouldn't have to lie to her face. "She really liked you." A tear rolled down her cheek," What did she said to you?" "She said that I was right about Ron. That he was having an affair. I knew it anyway, she just confirmed it." "How would she know," I said. "For God's sake, Claire, she just met you." "All the signs are there," she sniffled. "I just didn't want to see them." Claire was supposed to go to an

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audition. She had told Ron she would, but she had me call in and say she was sick. Ron was supposed to be home on Friday, but something came up. His trips home were handholds for her, so she could swing from one square on the calendar to the next. When he said he was going to come home and didn't, she swung forward and grasped thin air, fell. I intercepted a letter from prison from my mother to Claire. In it, my mother advised a love potion to put in his food, but everything in the formula she sent looked poisonous to me. I wanted to hold her close, but something was pushing her away. I didn't think I could save her anymore. "Claire, you know he'll be back. He loves you, don't worry." I didn't care if he came back or not. I heard the squeak of the bedsprings as she turned over, the effort it took to get up, stumble the three steps to the door. She tumbled with the lock. I opened the door and she fell back into bed, still wearing that red bathrobe. "I'm so cold," she mumbled. "Come in with me." I got in, clothes and all. She put her cold feel on mine, her head on my shoulder. "Stay with me, promise. Don't leave." I held her cold

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hands, rested my head against hers as she fell asleep. Claire was still sleeping when I woke up. I got up, careful not to disturb her, and went out to the kitchen. After a while, I checked on Claire. She was still asleep. The room was dark gray, no morning light penetrated the French doors covered with blinds. She had one hand flung across the top of the pillow. Her mouth was open, but she wasn't snoring now. "Claire?" I put my face right to hers. She smelled of sherry and something metallic. She didn't move. I put my hand on her shoulder, shook her gently. "Claire?" She didn't do anything. I couldn't hear her breathing. I shook her again. "Claire, wake up." I yelled at her, hoping she would open her eyes. It was impossible. "Claire." I screamed into her sleeping face. Nothing. I searched the bedside table, the floor. On the far side, I found the pills on the floor, along with the empty sherry bottle. The pill bottle was open, the pills spilled out, small pink tablets. Butalan, the label said. For Insomnia. Do Not Take With Alcohol. The sounds I was making were no long screams. I knocked the bedside light off the nightstand. I pulled the magnet box from

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under the bed and threw it across the room. I took her silver-backed hairbrush and threw it overhead like a baseball into the round mirror. I took the phone off the receiver against the headboard until it came apart in my hands, leaving dents in the soft pine. I lay my head on her chest where there was no heartbeat. She was so pale. Cold. Maybe she hadn't meant to. She would have written a note, explaining everything two or five ways. Maybe all she wanted was to sleep. The house was still. I heard the tick of the clock on the bedside table. A car drove past in the street. Fresh air came through the windows. She lay with her mouth open on the flowered pillow in her red bathrobe in the brightness of the morning.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Janet Fitch
ISBN: 978-0316284950
Publisher: Back Bay Books
Date (Month/Year): May 2000

AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2003 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier

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